

sinkers, who were continually being brought up more dead than alive, from the obnoxious gas they had inhaled in their endeavours to extract the buried miners."

Such disinterested labours—such self-denying philanthropy, ought not to be allowed to pass away unrecognised by those of their professional brethren whose circumstances will enable them to join in offering to each and all of these gentlemen some lasting testimonial of the high sense which the profession throughout the country entertain of their conduct, so far above all praise.

Mr. Ward I know not at all personally. I once had the pleasure of meeting Mr. Davison in consultation, not very long, indeed, before this melancholy event occurred; and he will pardon me, I am sure, for saying that, after having thus made his acquaintance, I was quite prepared to receive the testimony which is now so publicly borne to his goodness, and his inflexible determination to do his duty at any sacrifice, and at any cost.

I now, sir, commit to your charge my appeal to the medical profession throughout the country; and I trust that numbers will be ready to join, according to their means, in showing, first to these gentlemen, and then to the world, that we are, as a profession, united together, and united to give honour where *such* honour is due.

I am, etc., GEORGE KENNION, M.D., M.R.C.P.

Harrogate, February 12th, 1862.

[Dr. Kennion has kindly offered to receive subscriptions for the proposed object, and himself heads the list with a donation of £5. EDITOR.]

CAN SYPHILIS BE COMMUNICATED BY VACCINATION.

LETTER FROM WILLIAM ACTON, ESQ.

SIR,—I lately read with great interest an analysis which appeared in your JOURNAL of the 15th instant, p. 177, of two lectures recently delivered by M. Ricord on the question, "Can syphilis pass into the body with vaccine matter?"

That summary, if accurate, compels the conclusion that the professor of the Hôpital du Midi has lately modified his views with regard to the possibility of secondary symptoms being inoculable. I have since read the opinions of Ricord himself, as reported in two French medical journals, the *Gazette des Hôpitaux* and *L'Union Médicale*; and the writer of your article will, I hope, excuse my dissenting from the interpretation he has put upon the learned professor's words.

The lectures in question were given on the case of a young married woman, 18 years of age, who entered the Hôpital Dieu, in consequence of catarrh of the neck of the womb, but presented no traces of syphilis. As there were several cases of small-pox in the hospital, this woman was vaccinated with lymph taken from the arm of a child that had itself been vaccinated with lymph preserved at the Academy of Medicine. Four or five days afterwards, there remained no trace of the punctures. Fifteen days later, this woman quitted the hospital. Twenty-three days after the vaccination, she returned to the institution, and called the attention of the authorities to two out of the six punctures made in her arm, which had taken on the character of pustules of ecthyma. Fifteen days later, the ecthymatous pustules had not disappeared, but were larger. This created no alarm, as they were supposed to be late pustules, which had become aggravated by the patient's scratching them, or removing the scabs. When M. Ricord examined the patient, he declared that she presented the appearances of syphilis. On the arm, he noticed two tubercles, each with a large hard and raised base. The usual separation between the neighbouring parts and the tubercle was very obvious. In the axilla, a number of enlarged glands were noticed. Roseola appeared on the skin.

"This," said M. Ricord, "is one of the varieties of indurated chancre called *ulcus elevatum*. It is a chancre which has undergone transformation *in situ*. In the case of contagion which we witness to-day in this woman now in the hospital, we cannot be certain how the poison entered the system. There is in this case, as in many others, a coexistence of syphilis and vaccination; but, until the proof is more complete, I exclude the thought of syphilis being transmitted by vaccination. . . . For my part, I cannot deny that there is, in the different cases which we have passed in review, a coincidence between the appearance of syphilis and the appearance of vaccination (*variole*); but, up to the present time, I perceive no relation between these two affections; at least, no relation of causality. Is the case of this young woman surrounded with sufficient guarantees to prove the possibility of the transmission of syphilis by vaccination? Assuredly not. A young child is taken from this hospital (Hôtel Dieu) to the Academy to be vaccinated. The pustules develop themselves regularly. The pus serves to vaccinate four other children, in whom all passes normally. This young woman is inoculated with the same lymph; no pustule appears; for she had been previously vaccinated. She had left the hospital a month, and had been lost sight of. One morning she returns; two out of the six punctures which had been made in the arm presented traces of indurated chancres. Can you say that this is, necessarily, the effect of vaccination? May not this woman, who is married, have contracted syphilis out of the hospital, and contracted it in her arm? Would there be anything very extraordinary in this?"

In the report given in the *Gazette Médicale de Lyon*, M. Ricord says:—"Let me now say a word on the contagion of secondary symptoms. Between me and my opponents a long struggle has taken place on this important point of *syphilographie*. . . . I have failed on every occasion when I have endeavoured to inoculate secondary symptoms. . . . In the actual state of the question, it is not yet possible to lay down any certain conclusions. New facts—perhaps of immense importance—may be about to occur. Let us not hasten to pronounce an opinion; let us wait, and impartially examine; let us rather quietly reflect on every new fact as it happens; and, above all, let us examine every apparent novelty without being hampered by preconceived notions, so as one of these days to be able to draw an impartial conclusion."

Thus speaks M. Ricord in 1862. In 1859—the last time that this important question was before the Academy of Medicine—the learned professor spoke with equal caution. He terminated his speech by giving the following very qualified assent to the report:—"Admit, if you will, the possibility of the contagion of secondary symptoms, but do not specify anything at present. *Fiat lux*." (*Acton on Diseases of the Generative Organs*, 3rd edition, p. 407.)

I think, sir, that it is difficult to gather from Ricord's own words that he has changed any of his opinions. I confess it seems to me that he is as convinced as ever that secondary symptoms are not inoculable. His cautious language has been mistaken, and cited, I believe in some cases wilfully, as a proof that he has changed his opinions. My own experience, theoretical and practical, during twenty years, certainly justifies Ricord's caution. I have never met with a single well authenticated instance of the contagion of secondary symptoms. Many cases have been brought forward like this recent instance in Paris, but one and all have broken down when closely investigated. It is important that this should be known, as it affects the popularity of vaccination. Hitherto, notwithstanding all the charges of this kind that have been brought against vaccination, it still has the confidence of the profession.

I trust, sir, that these remarks may help to convince

some, who have had doubts on the subject, that vaccination is not proved to have ever yet been the means of introducing syphilis into the system. We must wait for facts a good deal more trustworthy, and a good deal more decisive, before we dethrone Jenner, and abandon ourselves and our children to small-pox.

I am, etc.,

W. ACTON.

Medical News.

ROYAL COLLEGE OF PHYSICIANS OF LONDON. At the Comitia Majora, held on Saturday, February 15th, the following gentleman was duly admitted a member of the College:—

Purdie, Robert, M.D., Blackheath

At the same Comitia, the following gentlemen, having undergone the necessary examination, and satisfied the College of their proficiency in the science and practice of Medicine and Midwifery, were duly admitted to practise physic as Licentiates of the College:—

Agar, Frederick, Tottenham
Buszard, Frank, M.B., Lutterworth
Campbell, Robert Lyons, Inverness
Muscroft, Henry, Pontefract
Sandford, Horace Vavasour, M.D., Hatfield, Yorkshire
Walford, Walter Gilson, Sittingbourne

The following passed the *first part* of the professional examination for the licence of the College, on the 7th inst:—

Bartlett, Joseph James Henry, University College
Bottle, Alexander, University College
Carter, Frederick, London Hospital
Steward, Joseph Septimus, Medical School, Newcastle-upon-Tyne

ROYAL COLLEGES OF PHYSICIANS AND SURGEONS, EDINBURGH. The gentlemen whose names are subjoined, having passed the necessary examinations, have been admitted Licentiates of one or both of the above Colleges, as indicated by the initials following each name, viz.:—

Cowan, William Dudgeon, Musselburgh, L.R.C.P. and L.R.C.S.
Jackson, Burton, co. Kerry, L.R.C.P. and L.R.C.S.
McDonald, William, Limerick, L.R.C.P. and L.R.C.S.
Pullar, William Young, Edinburgh, L.R.C.S.
Sandison, John, Arbroath, L.R.C.S.
Suther, James Benjamin Fraser, Edinburgh, L.R.C.S.
Wilkinson, William Edward, Dublin, L.R.C.S.

APPOINTMENTS.

*GREENHOW, Edward H., M.D., appointed one of Her Majesty's Commissioners to inquire into the condition of Mines in Great Britain, with reference to the health and safety of persons employed in such mines.

PEARCE, John W., Esq., elected Consulting-Surgeon to the Infirmary, Peterborough.

SPURGIN, Frederick W., Esq., elected House-Surgeon to the Poplar Hospital.

*WALKER, Thomas J., M.B., elected Surgeon to the Infirmary, Peterborough.

*WAY, John, M.D., elected Honorary Attending Medical Officer to the Royal Pimlico Dispensary, in the room of C. J. B. Meadows, M.D., resigned.

ROYAL ARMY. The following appointments have been made:—

BAXTER, Staff-Assistant-Surgeon P. C., M.B., half-pay, to be Staff-Assistant-Surgeon, *vice* J. H. Porter.

BRAYBROOKE, Surgeon W., Military Train, to be Staff-Surgeon, *vice* H. H. Jones, M.D.

D'ARCEY, Staff-Surgeon O'Connor, M.D., to be Surgeon Military Train, *vice* W. Braybrooke.

GUY, Surgeon T., M.D., Royal Artillery, to be Surgeon-Major, having completed twenty years full-pay service.

PORTER, Staff-Assistant-Surgeon J. H., to be Staff-Surgeon, *vice* O'C. D'Arcey, M.D.

VOLUNTEER CORPS. The following appointments have been made (A.V.=Artillery Volunteers; R.V.=Rifle Volunteers):—

SAVERY, J., M.D., to be Surgeon 1st Administrative Battalion Cinque Ports R.V.

To be Honorary Assistant-Surgeon:—

MONRO, J., M.D., 7th North Riding R.V.

BIRTHS.

HARRIES. On February 14th, at Shrewsbury, the wife of *J. D. Harries, Esq., of a daughter.

KEVERN. At Hull, on February 7th, the wife of *C. T. S. Kevern, Esq., Staff-Surgeon R.N., of a daughter.

DEATHS.

AINSWORTH. On February 15th, at Lower Broughton, aged 76, Elizabeth, widow of J. Ainsworth, Esq., Surgeon, of Manchester.

ECCLLES. On November 30th, 1861, on board the *Chile*, on her voyage to New Zealand, Maria, wife of Alfred Eccles, Esq., Surgeon.

GARNER, Robert, C., Esq., Surgeon, on board the *St. Lawrence*, at Calcutta, aged 23, on December 26, 1861.

KEVERN. On February 16th, at Hull, aged 39, Harriet, wife of *Charles T. S. Kevern, Esq., Staff-Surgeon R.N.

ROSE. On February 17th, at High Wycombe, aged 12, Robert Walter, second son of *William Rose, Esq.

NAVY ESTIMATES. The estimate this year for medicines and medical stores for the navy is £66,000; being the same as last year.

ROYAL COLLEGE OF SURGEONS. Professor Gulliver, F.R.S., will commence his course of lectures on the Blood of Vertebrata on Tuesday next, the 25th inst., at four o'clock.

ARMY MEDICAL DEPARTMENT. In the House of Commons, on Friday week, Sir G. C. Lewis, in reply to Colonel Sykes, said that it was not intended to admit natives of India to compete for the situation of army surgeons, the Medical Board having reported that the natives of India or other tropical countries would never be able to sustain the climate of a northern region. With respect to that part of the question which related to the coloured subjects of Canada being allowed to compete, he was not at all aware whether the hon. gentleman meant red Indians or free negroes. He was not aware that such a class of persons could compete.

A TEST FOR ARSENIC. Dr. Letheby recommends the following method of detecting the presence of arsenic in wreaths and dresses: "Put a drop of strong liquid ammonia (liquor ammonie, the druggist calls it) upon the green leaf, or dress, or paper, and if it turn blue, copper is present; and copper is rarely, if ever, present in these tissues and fabrics without arsenic being also present—the green compound being arsenite of copper. I have tested papers and dresses in this manner more than a hundred times, and have never failed to discover arsenic when the ammonia changes the green into blue. It is, therefore, indirectly, a very reliable test; and if every lady would carry with her, when she is shopping, a small phial of liquid ammonia, instead of the usual scent bottle, the mere touch of the wet stopper on the suspicious green would betray the arsenical poison and settle the business immediately."

A PYTHONESS. The Pythoness in the Zoological Gardens, is one of the large varieties of the great boa family. It was born in West Africa, and has been 11 years in the gardens, during which period it has thriven well, waxing yearly in strength, girth, and length, until now it is a very giant among the serpents in the Zoological Society's collection. It is better off than many animals in the gardens, which live in single blessedness in their narrow prison-houses, for the great lady Python has a husband. We must say, however, as will be seen presently, she does not seem to derive any great comfort from his society. It may be that, because her mate is much less than herself, she regards and treats him with contempt. He is a dwarf compared to her, being a kind of reptilian Brummell, toying, as it were, with peas while his wife eats scores of animals. She has gorged ten full-grown rabbits at a sitting, or coiling rather; and on the last occasion that we saw the interesting couple at their dinner (provided every Friday at the fashionable hour of 7) she stowed four rabbits in her elongated maw in an ama-